THE NOBULOUS SET · CAMPAIGN SUPPLEMENT

Designed by Jonathan Weeks

# Nobulous Research Journal (NRJ)

*Three games. One terrible idea.*

The Journal reveals that Build-a-Tyrant (BAT), the Nobulous Apprenticeship Program (NAP) and the Automaton of Shale (AoS) were never separate jobs. NAP supplied the knowledge and the brain, BAT supplied the body, AoS supplied the kidnapping and the cover-up. What remains is to walk the finished Imposter into the Council chamber and survive nine rounds of scrutiny.

## COMPONENTS

- 18 NRJ cards for BAT — 6 Experimental Protocols, 6 Unauthorized Modifications, 6 Research Notes
- 14 NRJ cards for NAP — 4 Following Setbacks, 4 Imposter Tasks, 6 Devious Opportunities
- 18 NRJ cards for AoS — 6 Nobulous Interference, 6 Corrupted Limitations, 6 Backdoor Routines
- 24 Council Test cards, printed as **Exhibits**
- **From 20 Strong:** the 17 unit dice — 4 Yellow, 4 Green, 4 Blue, 4 Purple and 1 Red — the 3 stat dice (Health, Strategy, Recovery) and the Chip
- Plus the components of whichever games you are playing

## WHAT NRJ ADDS

NRJ has two independent uses. You may use either, or both.

- **Overlay modules.** Optional cards that interfere with each standalone game. Three tiers per game.
- **The campaign.** Play all three games, carry your results forward, and finish with the Imposter Scenario.

> **THE TIERS ARE NOT DIFFICULTY LEVELS**
>
> **Tier I — Agenda** introduces Nobulous' interference. **Tier II — Contamination** injects corrupted material into the game's own decks and is the pressure peak. **Tier III — Exploitation** gives you tools to exploit the mess. Each tier includes the ones before it.

## BUILD-A-TYRANT (BAT) MODULE — 18 CARDS

| TIER | ADD |
|---|---|
| **I** | Draw 1 of the 6 **Experimental Protocols** at setup. |
| **II** | Remove 6 ordinary Upgrades from the Upgrade deck and shuffle the 6 **Unauthorized Modifications** in to replace them. Either a Rat or the Tyrant may hold them. |
| **III** | Lay the 6 **Research Notes** face-up near the table. Each prints its own claim condition; take a Note when you meet it, then spend it later for the one-shot reward printed on it. A Note can be claimed only once, and only one copy of each condition exists. |

## NOBULOUS APPRENTICESHIP PROGRAM (NAP) MODULE — 14 CARDS

| TIER | ADD |
|---|---|
| **I** | Shuffle in **3 of the 4 Following Setbacks**, chosen at random, and set aside **one of your difficulty's Setbacks for each one** — as far as you have them. A difficulty carrying 3 or more keeps the count it asks for, with 3 of them nastier; one carrying fewer has none left to give back, so Tier I *raises* its count to 3. At your difficulty that is: Easy 3 Following and 0 base, Standard 3 and 0, Hard 3 and 0, Nobulous 3 and 1. An unresolved Following Setback moves into the next Time Slot, including Evening to the next Morning. A Following Setback does **not** lock the row: the restriction printed on the card replaces "no other Assignment may be worked until this Setback is resolved". **It moves before the next reveal** and counts toward the receiving row's 4-card limit; if that row is full, it stays where it is and tries to follow again at the next slot advance. Resolve an end-of-slot effect printed on the card *before* moving it. |
| **II** | Add the 4 **Imposter Tasks**, one per subject. Each replaces a Credit Task of the same subject, **chosen at random**, and inherits that Task's recovery-color dot. |
| **III** | Replace the 6 Opportunities with the 6 **Devious Opportunities**. |

Tier I used to set aside *all 6* base Setbacks for exactly 3 Following ones, and that is fixed as of 2026-11-07. It only ever matched at Easy and Standard, which play 3 Setbacks anyway; at Hard and Nobulous, which play 4 and 5, it meant that *turning the tier on handed a Setback back* — Tier I measured easier than no module at all on both rungs. A tier must never do that, so the swap is now one for one.

#### IMPOSTER TASKS

Imposter Tasks are **Mandatory** and **grant no Credits**. You still have to clear them; clearing them advances no subject. Both faces print a **recovery reward**, so clearing one can still help the next roll.
**An Imposter Task flips once.** Unresolved at the end of a Time Slot, it turns to its Demand side and keeps its stored progress. Unresolved again at the end of its Demand visit, it is **discarded** and its stored dice exhaust. These four print no Demand penalty, so there is none to pay.

*Neural Extraction Practicum* holds one contributing die on the card until End of Day; exhaust it **before** you recover for REC. On *Load-Bearing Prosthetics*, a Crit can supply both of the same-color successes by itself, and the ordinary color rule still applies on top.

#### DEVIOUS OPPORTUNITIES BANK THEIR HELP

Four of the six pay nothing when you complete them: you **keep the card and spend it once during the Final Exam** — or **discard it during the apprenticeship to ignore one Setback's restrictions for the rest of the game**. That Setback stays in its Time Slot and still has to be resolved; it simply stops charging upkeep and stops restricting what else you may work. The other two — *Borrow the Master's Notes* and *Extra Credit?* — resolve immediately, because an exam has no room for them. Tier III replaces the base Opportunities, so NAP's own coupons are not in the deck at this tier: your Opportunity rewards are **banked for the exams** instead of spent along the way. Spending one is free and costs no dice.
A Devious Opportunity keeps the **normal Opportunity lifetime** — one rotation for a final chance, in the same Time Slot on the following day. *Borrow the Master's Notes* finishes an **optional** non-Credit Request, which rules out the Mandatory Imposter Tasks; exhaust that Task's stored dice, then pay its own Request reward. *Extra Credit?* names the subject of the most recently completed **Credit** Task, and resolves after any Credit Tasks finishing on the same roll.

## AUTOMATON OF SHALE (AOS) MODULE — 18 CARDS

| TIER | ADD |
|---|---|
| **I** | Draw 1 of the 6 **Nobulous Interference** cards at setup. |
| **II** | Shuffle the 6 **Corrupted Limitations** into the Limitation deck. |
| **III** | Lay the 6 **Backdoor Routines** face-up near the table. Each prints a claim condition and a later one-shot use. **You may claim at most 2 per game** — once you have claimed 2 you cannot claim more, even if you meet the other conditions. |

Corrupted Limitations are revealed before required-color dice are committed, exactly like native Limitations, and withhold 2 dice of a *randomly selected* color on top of their printed corruption. A withheld color cannot answer a required-color dot, exactly as it cannot under a native Limitation.

They used to exclude the colors the Program required, and that exclusion is gone as of 2026-11-06. A Corrupted Limitation is drawn *instead of* a native one, so while it dodged the colors you needed it was the gentler of the two — a native Shortage has never consulted the requirements — and the relief of dodging a native Limitation paid for the corruption almost exactly. The whole of Tier II was worth a tenth of a point. The case the exclusion guarded against is one this game already prices: a Program whose required color you cannot supply is not executed, costs 1 Health and counts as failed, which is a real outcome with a real cost rather than a hole in the rules.

## PLAYING THE CAMPAIGN

1. **Play at Tier III.** The campaign is Tier III only, because the Research Pool is built out of the Tier III cards themselves — see below. Tiers I and II are for playing the three games on their own.
2. Win BAT, NAP and AoS in any order. **If you lose a game, replay that game only** — the campaign does not restart.
3. Each won game contributes its 6 Tier III cards to the **Research Pool**.
4. Play the Imposter Scenario.

No written bookkeeping is needed. Physical cards and their printed states carry the whole campaign history, and nothing is taken out of the BAT, NAP or AoS decks — every card the finale uses came from this box.

### The Research Pool — the Tier III cards you claimed

The Council's evidence against you is the Nobulous material you touched. Each game lays 6 Tier III cards on the table and every one of them is a favor: claim it and that game gets easier. The finale is where the favor is counted.

| GAME | TIER III CARDS | ANSWERS | CLAIMED BY |
|---|---|---|---|
| **BAT** | 6 Research Notes | Physical | meeting the printed condition and giving up the next Upgrade a completed Experiment earns |
| **NAP** | 6 Devious Opportunities | Knowledge | working it like an Assignment, in place of a Credit Task |
| **AoS** | 6 Backdoor Routines | Cover-Up | meeting the printed condition and giving up the next Program Reward |

**A card you claimed is retained. A card you never claimed is a candidate.** That is the whole of it. Whether you went on to spend the card during its own game makes no difference — nothing on the table records that, and a campaign can sit for weeks between games.

| GAME | RETAIN AT MOST | WHY THAT MANY |
|---|---|---|
| **NAP** | **3** | an Opportunity is worked like an Assignment, and apprentices finish about two and a half of them |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **BAT** | **2** | a second Note already costs the Rats about nine points in the model, and a third is never worth taking |
| **AoS** | **2** | AoS's own claim limit |

Every retained card reduces one Exhibit's Target by **2**. If you claimed more than you may retain, choose which to carry. Keep all 18 face-up and available; a card spent in the finale is gone for the rest of it.

### TIER III IS A LOAN AND THE FINALE IS THE RECKONING

Every one of these cards exists to make its own game easier, and claiming one makes that game harder: a Research Note costs the next Upgrade a completed Experiment earns, a Backdoor Routine the next Program Reward. So the campaign asks each game a question it cannot answer on its own — how much of your own margin will you give up to arm the Imposter? It is a real price, not a flourish. In the design model a Research Note costs BAT about 6 points of win rate and a second about 9 more, and a Backdoor Routine costs AoS a Program Reward it misses badly. And it buys the whole finale: the model reads about 51% walking in with a full pool against about 9% with none. Those are figures from the simulation rather than from recorded play — see *About the percentages*.

## THE IMPOSTER SCENARIO

The Council has assembled a **Dossier** on you. Each card in it is an **Exhibit** — one thing they intend to ask about. You cannot refuse it and you cannot outrun it; you can only decide how much of it to face at a time, and you have nine sessions before the Council rules.

1. Deal 5 Knowledge, 5 Physical and 5 Cover-Up Exhibits at random from the 24-card Council Test library. Shuffle those 15 into a face-down **Dossier**.
2. Each Exhibit prints its **Target**, its **Damage** and a **Reward**. Only **five** of the Rewards do anything, and those five are in **bold**; the rest are the Council being gracious, and are set in *italics* to say so. Nothing else on the card is used.
3. Choose one **Imposter** card and one of its two sides; the ability is printed on the card. The Imposter begins at **5 HP / 2 STR / 3 REC** with all 17 dice, less however many the difficulty you chose starts exhausted.
4. Keep the Research Pool face-up near the table.
5. Play **9 sessions**.

### YOU WIN BY CLEARING THE DOSSIER, AND YOU LOSE TWO WAYS

**Win** the moment the Dossier is empty and no Exhibit is left standing. **Lose** if the ninth session ends with any Exhibit still in the Dossier or on the table, or if your Health ever reaches 0. Either way you replay the finale, not the campaign.

### Four difficulties

The Imposter walks into the chamber already tired, and how tired is the difficulty. **Begin with these dice exhausted** — the level names them, so there is nothing to choose. They come back through ordinary recovery, so the handicap costs tempo rather than dice: it bites hardest in the early sessions, when the Dossier is full and falling behind the clock is how you lose.

| LEVEL | YELLOW | GREEN | BLUE | PURPLE | MODEL WIN RATE |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Easy** | — | — | — | — | about 1 game in 2 |
| **Standard** | 3 | 2 | 2 | 2 | about 2 games in 5 |
| **Hard** | 3 | 3 | 3 | 2 | about 3 games in 10 |
| **Nobulous** | 3 | 3 | 4 | 4 | about 1 game in 5 |

### ABOUT THE PERCENTAGES

Every percentage in this supplement comes from the design simulation, not from recorded play. Each is the mean of twenty thousand games played by one fixed policy — a competent policy, but neither an optimal one nor a human one. They are the targets the difficulty was tuned against, and they are the right way to compare one rung, one Imposter or one Research Pool against another.

They are not a promise about your table. A real group will beat them or miss them depending mostly on how it reads the clock. And a figure quoted for BAT, NAP or AoS was measured inside that game's own model rather than across the campaign, so treat it as a price tag on a decision rather than a forecast.

The single Red die is never exhausted at setup: session 5 allows only Red and Yellow, and you own exactly one Red. The counts are spread across the colors on purpose. Exhausting whole colors instead would empty whichever window the attention opens on — all four Yellow and all four Green costs twice what the same eight dice cost taken off the Purple end — and that would make the wheel's phase the difficulty rather than the handicap.

### The five Imposters

Choose one Imposter — **The Archivist**, **The Understudy**, **The Usher**, **The Porter** or **The Steward** — and one of its two sides. All five begin at **5 HP / 2 STR / 3 REC** and differ only in the ability printed on the card, so which side you take is a decision about how you intend to play rather than about how hard the Scenario is. Every side was measured at Easy and at a hard setting, and in the model none is worth more than about four games in a hundred.

**The Understudy is the only one who spends Candidates.** The cards you never claimed come to the chamber and answer nothing — for every other Imposter they are a record of what you could not afford. Giving all of them a use was tried and rejected: any help available to everyone is worth almost nothing at Easy and a great deal once dice start exhausted, which quietly re-scales every rung of the ladder.

### The Council's attention

The Council examines one aspect of you at a time, and you can see what they will turn to next. The **attention** starts on Yellow and advances one step at the end of every session:

Yellow → Green → Blue → Purple → Red → back to Yellow.

You may only **apply** dice of the attention's color **or the next color on that list**. Other dice may still be committed and rolled — they simply cannot be applied, and they exhaust like any other committed die. Every color is therefore usable for two consecutive sessions, which is what makes recovery a plan rather than a reflex: recover for the color that is *coming*, not the one in front of you.

| SESSION | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | **5** | 6 | 7 | 8 | 9 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| ATTENTION | ● | ● | ● | ● | ● | ● | ● | ● | ● |

Session 5 is the hard one: Red and Yellow are the only colors you may apply, and you own exactly one Red die. Session 9 is the kindest, Purple and Red — so the Dossier should be nearly empty well before the Council's attention comes back around.

### A session

1. **Deploy.** Take as many Exhibits as you like from the top of the Dossier — any number, including none — and place them face-up in front of you. For *each* one you deploy, **recover 1 exhausted die**, or mend 1 Health if nothing is exhausted.
2. **Answer the evidence.** Spend Research Pool cards on the Exhibits you just deployed (below). Exhibits deployed in an earlier session can no longer be answered.
3. **Strategy, twice.** Commit dice, roll, and apply hits to your standing Exhibits: a hit is 1 success, a Crit is 2, and only the allowed colors may be applied. Then take up the dice that missed and throw again. Nothing is compulsory.
4. **Resolve**, in this order:
   1. Every Exhibit *still standing* deals its Damage to you.
   2. Exhaust every committed die that applied nothing, and every die lying on an Exhibit that has just fallen.
   3. Take the Reward of each Exhibit that fell, if it is one of the five that pay.
   4. Recover up to **REC** exhausted dice.
   5. Advance the attention and tick the clock.

   Steps 2 to 4 are in that order for a reason: a Reward that recovers dice may take back the very dice that just buried the card, and it is read *before* your REC recovery, while the most dice are still exhausted.

An Exhibit falls when the successes on it meet or exceed its Target. **Dice applied to an Exhibit that is still standing stay on it, and the successes they scored stay with them** — progress on an Exhibit is never lost, and those dice are neither available nor exhausted until the card falls.

### What the Council lets slip

Every Exhibit prints a Reward and **five of them pay**. Those five are printed in **bold** and begin "*When this Exhibit falls*"; take the Reward at **step 3 of Resolve** — after the dice on the fallen Exhibit have been exhausted, and before your REC recovery. The other nineteen are printed in *italics* and are worth exactly what the Council intends them to be worth.

- **The Chamber Mechanism** — recover 2 exhausted dice.
- **The Sedative Ledger** — recover 3 exhausted dice.
- **The Vote** — recover *all* exhausted dice of one color.
- **Tracks in the Yard** — recover 1 exhausted die of each of two colors.
- **The Narrow Stair** — the next Exhibit you deploy has its Target reduced by 1.

A Reward is one reason it matters *which* Exhibit you finish first, and not the only one: a standing Exhibit deals its Damage every session, and the dice lying on it are neither available nor exhausted until it falls. Burying the high-Damage card, and freeing a die that has been held for three sessions, both pay without any Reward involved. What the Rewards add is a reason to go after the *cheap* evidence as well: four of the five are Target 3 as dealt, so the cheapest evidence is also the evidence that pays.

### Answering an Exhibit

A **retained** card answers only its own domain, and reduces the Target of one Exhibit you have just deployed. A card you spend is gone. Candidates answer nothing at all — unless you took the Understudy, who is the one Imposter that spends them.

| RETAINED CARD | ANSWERS | REDUCTION |
|---|---|---|
| **BAT Research Note** | Physical | −2 |
| **NAP Devious Opportunity** | Knowledge | −2 |
| **AoS Backdoor Routine** | Cover-Up | −2 |
| **Candidate** | — | 0 |

At most seven retained cards against fifteen Exhibits — 3 from NAP, 2 from BAT and 2 from AoS: the campaign answers under half the Dossier at best, and only while the right domains come up. No Exhibit drops below Target 1.

### The decision the finale is built on

Deploying more than you must is how you get ahead of the clock, and each Exhibit pays you a die for it. Deploying more than you can *bury* is how you bleed. Count the Exhibits left against the sessions left and do not fall behind that number — slowing down when Health is short feels prudent and loses games, because the clock kills more reliably than the Council does.

*Terminology:* the **Research Pool** is the 18 carried-forward cards. The **Dossier** is the 15 Exhibits. The **dice pool** is the Imposter's dice.

## STANDALONE IMPOSTER MODE

You can play the finale without the campaign, and without opening another box: every card it needs is in this one. Take the 6 Research Notes, the 6 Devious Opportunities and the 6 Backdoor Routines. Draw at random **3 Opportunities, 2 Notes and 2 Routines** as retained — the campaign's own caps — and leave the other eleven as Candidates. Build the 15-card Dossier normally, pick a difficulty, and play the nine-session finale.

NRJ · The Nobulous Set · fan expansion for 20 Strong · prototype rules, not affiliated with Chip Theory Games